

Guide 19 — Paralegal and Legal Assistant

Controlled English working master, version 2

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1. Purpose and scope

Paralegals and legal assistants perform substantive legal-support work for lawyers, law offices, corporations, government agencies, legal-service organizations, and other authorized employers. Typical work may include factual investigation, legal research, document preparation, case-file management, client and witness support, discovery, transaction support, filing preparation, trial preparation, and matter workflow.

This occupation is materially different from general office administration because the work may contribute directly to legal matters. That does **not** make a paralegal a lawyer. The title alone does not authorize independent legal advice, independent representation, formation of an attorney-client relationship, fee-setting, legal strategy, or any activity reserved by law to licensed or otherwise authorized professionals.

The safest career rule is simple: **perform only work you are qualified, assigned, supervised, and legally permitted to perform in the jurisdiction and setting where you work.**

This guide covers practical entry routes in the United States and Canada, free-first and verification-first options in Colombia and Latin America, current wage and labor-market evidence, education and workforce funding, accessibility, privacy and cybersecurity, responsible AI, job-search preparation, and career progression.

2. Role definition and legal-practice boundary

United States occupational mapping

The principal U.S. occupational reference is **O*NET 23-2011.00 — Paralegals and Legal Assistants**. O*NET describes the occupation as assisting lawyers by investigating facts, preparing legal documents, and researching legal precedent. Reported titles include Immigration Paralegal, Legal Analyst, Legal Assistant, Legal Clerk, Litigation Paralegal, Paralegal, Paralegal Specialist, and Real Estate Paralegal.

The American Bar Association defines a paralegal as a person qualified by education, training, or work experience who is employed or retained by a lawyer, law office, corporation, governmental agency, or other entity and performs specifically delegated substantive legal work for which a lawyer is responsible.

Work that may be delegated

Depending on jurisdiction, employer, supervision, competence, and assigned authority, work may include:

- factual and legal research;
- organizing and analyzing records, evidence, and case materials;
- drafting documents for attorney or authorized-professional review;
- preparing discovery, chronologies, summaries, exhibits, closing sets, or filing packages;
- interviewing clients or witnesses within approved boundaries;
- maintaining case-management and litigation-support systems;
- tracking deadlines and procedural requirements under approved workflows;
- supporting due diligence, transactions, hearings, trials, or closings;
- communicating approved factual or procedural information;
- coordinating filings, service, records requests, or document production;
- supporting e-discovery and document review;
- protecting confidential, privileged, work-product, and nonpublic matter information.

Work the title does not authorize by itself

Ordinary paralegal status does not independently authorize a person to:

- give individualized legal advice;
- decide legal strategy without authorized professional judgment;
- establish an attorney-client relationship;
- set legal fees;
- represent a client in court or before an agency unless a specific law or rule permits it;
- sign documents when a lawyer or other specifically authorized professional must sign;
- hold themselves out as a lawyer;
- perform a service that the applicable jurisdiction reserves to licensed or otherwise authorized persons.

Some U.S. states and agencies permit defined nonlawyer services or representation under specific programs. Those exceptions must be verified individually. They do not convert ordinary paralegal employment into a nationwide independent-practice license.

Safe escalation rule: if a task requires legal judgment, advice, interpretation, representation, a reserved signature, or authority you have not verified, stop and escalate to the supervising lawyer or other authorized professional.

3. Common titles and workplaces

Possible job titles include:

- Paralegal
- Legal Assistant
- Litigation Paralegal
- Corporate Paralegal
- Immigration Paralegal
- Real Estate Paralegal
- Contracts Paralegal
- Legal Analyst
- Paralegal Specialist
- Legal Clerk
- Case Assistant
- Practice Support Specialist

Potential workplaces include:

- private law firms;
- corporate legal departments;
- banks and financial institutions;
- insurance organizations;
- government legal offices and agencies;
- courts and public-sector legal organizations;
- nonprofit legal-service providers;
- real estate and title organizations;
- healthcare and life-sciences organizations;
- compliance, regulatory, investigations, and contracts teams.

Titles overlap. A “legal assistant” may be primarily administrative in one organization and substantially paralegal in another. Read the duties, supervision structure, education requirements, and jurisdictional rules rather than relying on title alone.

4. Daily work and responsibilities

Research and factual investigation

Paralegals may research statutes, regulations, cases, court rules, public records, corporate records, property records, or other sources under authorized workflows. Good work requires source discipline: record where information came from, distinguish binding authority from secondary explanation, capture dates and jurisdictions, and escalate uncertain legal conclusions.

Drafting and document preparation

Work may include preparing first drafts of pleadings, discovery, correspondence, contracts, forms, chronologies, summaries, transaction documents, closing materials, or internal memoranda for authorized review. Templates reduce repetitive work but do not replace verification.

Case and matter management

You may organize files, maintain indexes, track deadlines, prepare task lists, manage exhibits, coordinate signatures, monitor discovery, maintain matter metadata, and document status. Deadline errors can have serious consequences, so use approved calendaring and double-check procedures.

Client and witness support

Depending on the role, you may gather facts, collect records, schedule interviews, prepare questionnaires, help organize evidence, or provide approved process information. Do not convert an interview or status update into independent legal advice.

Litigation, transaction, and regulatory support

Specialized roles may support depositions, hearings, trials, mergers and acquisitions, real estate closings, immigration filings, intellectual-property matters, investigations, compliance reviews, regulatory submissions, or contract lifecycle work.

5. Core skills and technology

Useful skills include:

- legal and factual research discipline;
- professional writing, editing, and proofreading;
- reading comprehension;
- critical thinking;
- active listening and interviewing;
- organization and deadline management;
- source and citation verification;

- confidentiality and discretion;
- document review and comparison;
- records and evidence organization;
- accurate data entry;
- professional client communication;
- escalation judgment;
- ability to learn specialized legal terminology and procedures without exceeding role authority.

Common technology categories may include:

- word processing and spreadsheets;
- PDF and redaction tools;
- document-management systems;
- case- and matter-management systems;
- legal research platforms;
- e-discovery and review platforms;
- court and agency electronic-filing systems;
- contract-management systems;
- secure file-sharing and collaboration tools;
- time and billing systems;
- approved AI, search, summarization, or document-automation tools.

At entry level, disciplined use of systems, verification, confidentiality, and workflow control usually matters more than claiming expertise in every product.

6. Entry requirements, education, certification, and regulation

United States

The U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics identifies **associate's degree** as the typical entry-level education for paralegals and legal assistants. BLS also notes that paralegals typically need an associate's degree or certificate in paralegal studies, although employer expectations vary and some employers prefer a bachelor's degree or may consider relevant experience.

Before paying for education, distinguish these concepts carefully:

- **Paralegal certificate program:** an education program completed by a student; it is not the same as individual professional certification.
- **Individual certification:** a credential awarded by a nongovernmental certifying organization after its requirements are met.
- **ABA-approved education program:** the ABA approves qualifying paralegal education programs; it does not certify individual paralegals.
- **Institutional accreditation:** recognition of an educational institution by an accrediting body; this is separate from ABA program approval.

- **State regulation or registration:** jurisdiction-specific requirements governing titles, qualifications, registration, continuing education, or practice conditions.
- **Limited legal-service license:** a separate state-created authorization allowing defined services under defined conditions; it is not ordinary paralegal status.

The ABA states that **California is currently the only U.S. state that directly regulates paralegals** by requiring people using paralegal/legal-assistant titles to meet specified education or experience and continuing-education requirements. The ABA also states that there is **no mandatory certification examination for paralegals anywhere in the United States** and that the ABA does **not** certify individual paralegals.

Do not describe yourself as “ABA-certified.” If you completed an ABA-approved paralegal education program, describe that fact accurately.

Limited-license programs

The ABA reported in February 2026 that Arizona, Minnesota, Oregon, and Utah issue some form of limited license allowing qualifying nonlawyers to provide specified legal services in defined circumstances. Eligibility, title, permitted services, supervision, education, examination, and regulatory obligations differ by state.

Do not assume a paralegal credential qualifies you for one of these programs, and do not present these programs as a general U.S. paralegal license.

Canada

Government of Canada Job Bank maps paralegals and related occupations to **NOC 42200**. Requirements and independent-practice rules vary by province and role. Job Bank indicates that paralegals in law firms typically require legal education and in-house training, while independent paralegals may require specialized training or a community-college paralegal program. Job Bank also notes licensing for advanced legal services.

The practical rule is province-specific verification. A national NOC profile is not a uniform Canadian license.

Colombia and Latin America

There is no single Latin American paralegal credential or scope that transfers automatically across countries. Colombia’s official CUOC includes **34113 — Asistentes legales y afines**, but occupation classification does not itself authorize reserved legal services.

Use official education and occupational systems to verify programs and roles. In Colombia, higher-education programs should be checked through **SNIES**, including the institution and current Registro Calificado where applicable.

7. United States pathway

Step 1 — Study the actual occupation

Read O*NET 23-2011.00 and the current BLS profile. Compare the substantive legal work of paralegals with the more administrative work of legal secretaries and office coordinators.

Step 2 — Review current employer requirements

Read 15–20 current postings in the jurisdiction and practice areas you are targeting. Track repeated requirements such as:

- paralegal degree or certificate;
- bachelor's degree;
- legal research;
- litigation support;
- discovery and e-discovery;
- court e-filing;
- immigration forms and case systems;
- corporate governance and entity management;
- real estate or title work;
- document management;
- Microsoft 365 and PDF tools;
- bilingual communication;
- years of specialized experience.

Step 3 — Choose education only after evidence

Before paying for a private program:

1. verify that target employers actually value or require it;
2. verify institutional accreditation or recognition where relevant;
3. verify whether the paralegal program itself is ABA-approved if the provider claims that status;
4. compare total tuition, fees, schedule, refund rules, placement claims, and transferability;
5. check public, employer, workforce, and community-college options first.

Step 4 — Build supervised practical competence

Practice legal research, source logging, document formatting, proofreading, chronology creation, file organization, and deadline tracking using public or fictitious information. Real client or employer information belongs only in approved systems.

Step 5 — Specialize gradually

Common practice areas include litigation, corporate, contracts, real estate, immigration, intellectual property, employment, family law, bankruptcy, healthcare, government, regulatory,

and investigations work. Specialization can improve value, but only claim experience you actually possess.

8. Canada pathway

Canada's occupational reference in this guide is **NOC 42200 — Paralegals and related occupations**.

A practical sequence is:

1. review the current Job Bank requirements and wage profile;
2. identify the province or territory where you intend to work;
3. verify whether the target duties require licensing, registration, supervision, or another authorization;
4. compare real employer postings and recognized education pathways;
5. verify the institution and program before paying;
6. confirm work authorization and any province-specific professional requirements;
7. distinguish employment in a law firm from any permitted independent paralegal services.

Current national Job Bank wages reviewed for this edition show:

- **C\$21.63/hour low;**
- **C\$33.05/hour median;**
- **C\$52.19/hour high.**

The wage page was updated November 19, 2025 using Statistics Canada Labour Force Survey 2023–2024 data. These are national reference values, not guaranteed offers.

9. Latin America and Colombia pathway

Legal systems, professional titles, reserved activities, education pathways, courts, labor markets, and employer expectations vary across Latin America.

For any country:

- identify the official labor, justice, court, and education authorities;
- verify whether the role is administrative, substantive legal support, or a regulated professional function;
- distinguish occupational classification from legal authorization;
- read current employer postings;
- verify education recognition before paying;
- verify whether court-facing or client-facing activities have special rules.

Colombia occupational mapping

OCUPACOL / Ministerio del Trabajo identifies **CUOC 34113 — Asistentes legales y afines**. Listed titles include Asistente de abogado, Asistente de bufete de abogados, Asistente jurídico, Asistente legal, Auxiliar de abogacía, Auxiliar de servicios jurídicos, Dependiente judicial, Técnico judicial, and related titles.

The OCUPACOL page also displays older 2020–2021 market figures. Those values must **not** be treated as current 2026 salary evidence.

Colombia free-first foundation

SENA Betowa currently lists **Asistencia Administrativa** as a titled technical program with:

- **2,208 hours** duration;
- **Técnico** training level;
- displayed minimum age **14+**;
- admission subject to available places and SENA selection procedures.

The program can build transferable communication, document, customer-service, information-handling, and digital-office skills. It is **not** a law degree, paralegal license, or authorization to perform reserved legal services.

For higher education in Colombia, verify the institution and program in SNIES and confirm current Registro Calificado where required before paying.

10. Free and low-cost learning strategy

Use a free-first sequence:

1. employer onboarding and supervised work-based training;
2. official O*NET, BLS, Job Bank, OCUPACOL, SNIES, court, and regulator resources;
3. public libraries and recognized legal-information resources;
4. SENA in Colombia for transferable administrative foundations where useful;
5. American Job Centers and public workforce resources in the United States;
6. community-college or recognized higher-education programs when job evidence justifies the cost;
7. paid private programs only after verifying employer demand, recognition, total cost, refund terms, and realistic outcomes.

Useful low-risk practice topics include:

- source logging and citation checking;
- public-record research;
- fictitious case chronologies;
- document formatting and comparison;
- proofreading names, dates, citations, numbers, and exhibits;

- spreadsheet tracking;
- secure file naming and version control;
- professional interviewing using invented scenarios;
- confidentiality and privilege awareness;
- phishing and social-engineering awareness;
- AI-output verification using public sources.

Never use real client, witness, employee, transaction, investigation, or matter information in an unapproved learning environment.

11. Funding, scholarships, and employer support

FAFSA and federal student aid

The U.S. Free Application for Federal Student Aid (FAFSA) is free to submit. Eligible students at participating institutions may qualify for grants, Federal Work-Study, or federal student loans depending on individual and program eligibility.

Do not assume a private paralegal certificate qualifies. Verify the exact institution, program, and student eligibility through official Federal Student Aid resources before enrolling.

American Job Centers

American Job Centers provide local employment and training assistance. Services and eligibility vary. If workforce funding is important to your decision, obtain confirmation that the exact provider and program qualify before paying.

Employer educational assistance — Section 127

IRS guidance issued in April 2026 states that under a qualifying employer Section 127 educational-assistance program, up to **USD 5,250** of qualifying benefits may be excluded from an employee's gross income for calendar years 2025 and 2026, subject to the employer's plan and applicable rules. Cost-of-living adjustment applies for taxable years beginning after 2026.

USD 5,250 is **not** a guaranteed payment, scholarship, or tuition allowance. Obtain the employer's written plan terms before relying on reimbursement.

Scholarships and institutional aid

Search recognized schools, community foundations, professional associations, government programs, and established scholarship resources. Avoid claims of guaranteed scholarships, guaranteed jobs, guaranteed salaries, or pressure to pay immediately.

12. Work-based learning and apprenticeship

Paralegal competence develops strongly through supervised work because legal workflows are contextual and deadline-sensitive.

Useful work-based learning can include:

- internships;
- paid entry-level case-assistant roles;
- employer onboarding;
- mentoring;
- supervised document review;
- supervised research assignments;
- court- or agency-process training;
- practice-area-specific training;
- recognized apprenticeships where an exact program is verified.

Do not call an internship, ordinary employer training, or informal mentorship a Registered Apprenticeship unless the program's registration is verified through the responsible authority.

For any advertised registered apprenticeship:

1. obtain the exact sponsor and program name;
 2. verify the registration;
 3. verify the exact occupation;
 4. confirm wages, wage progression, related instruction, duration, costs, and obligations in writing.
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13. Income and labor-market research

Salary data are reference points, not promises. Compensation varies by jurisdiction, practice area, employer type, experience, education, technology, language skills, overtime, and specialization.

United States — official BLS data

For **Paralegals and Legal Assistants**, BLS reports:

- **May 2024 median annual wage:** USD 61,010;
- **median hourly equivalent:** approximately USD 29.33/hour;
- **employment in 2024:** 376,200;
- **projected employment in 2034:** 376,800;
- **2024–2034 change:** 0% — little or no change;
- **numeric change:** +600;
- **average openings:** approximately 39,300 per year, largely replacement openings.

Do not interpret 39,300 annual openings as 39,300 new jobs. BLS projects little or no net employment growth.

BLS also notes that AI and other technologies may improve efficiency in legal research and document preparation and may limit employment growth.

Current private U.S. market estimates

Private sources use different methodologies and should remain separate from BLS.

Indeed — Paralegal

Updated July 20, 2026: average base salary **USD 66,879/year**, based on approximately 12.1K salary observations from job postings over the prior 36 months.

ZipRecruiter — Paralegal

As of July 28, 2026: average **USD 59,731/year**, approximately **USD 28.72/hour**.

Do not average these values together or label them government statistics.

Canada — official Job Bank data

National NOC 42200 wages reviewed for this edition:

- low: **C\$21.63/hour**;
- median: **C\$33.05/hour**;
- high: **C\$52.19/hour**.

Before accepting an offer, compare base pay, hours, overtime, benefits, commute or remote requirements, education repayment, licensing obligations, training, confidentiality rules, and advancement potential.

14. Accessibility and accommodations

People may learn or work more effectively with structured information, assistive technology, modified workflows, or other accommodations.

Helpful approaches can include:

- numbered research and filing procedures;
- checklists for document packages and deadlines;
- written assignment instructions;
- templates and style guides;
- screen readers, magnification, speech-to-text, or other assistive technology where compatible with security requirements;
- focused proofreading passes for names, dates, citations, numbers, and attachments;
- calendar and task-management systems;
- quiet review periods for high-risk documents;
- accessible training materials;

- explicit escalation steps for uncertainty.

In U.S. covered employment settings, reasonable-accommodation rights depend on applicable law and the facts. Use the employer's formal process and consult the relevant authority or qualified professional for individualized questions.

15. Confidentiality, privacy, cybersecurity, and records protection

Paralegals may handle extremely sensitive information, including:

- client and prospective-client identities;
- privileged communications;
- attorney work product;
- legal strategy;
- investigation files;
- medical and financial records;
- contracts and transaction documents;
- discovery materials;
- witness information;
- personal identifiers;
- court and filing credentials;
- internal legal and business information.

Information-handling controls

- access only what is needed for authorized work;
- use approved storage, email, collaboration, research, and file-transfer systems;
- verify recipients before sending confidential material;
- apply approved redaction procedures;
- follow naming, retention, legal-hold, destruction, and access-control rules;
- do not move matter information to personal email, personal cloud storage, or personal messaging apps;
- do not photograph confidential files for convenience;
- do not reuse real matter data in personal portfolios, demos, or training exercises.

Authentication, phishing, and fraud

- protect passwords and MFA methods;
- never approve unexpected MFA prompts;
- verify unusual wire, payment, credential-reset, file-sharing, or urgent disclosure requests through approved channels;
- treat requests to bypass normal controls as possible social engineering;
- report suspected phishing, malware, misdirected email, lost devices, or unauthorized access immediately.

Filing and research systems

Court, agency, research, and document-review systems may have contractual or procedural restrictions. Use assigned credentials correctly and never file, disclose, alter, or submit substantive content outside your authorization.

16. Responsible use of artificial intelligence

Generative AI can support learning, summarization, drafting, classification, research assistance, and workflow efficiency, but legal environments require unusually strong confidentiality, competence, supervision, candor, and source-verification controls.

ABA Formal Opinion 512 addresses lawyers' professional-responsibility duties when using generative AI. Paralegals and legal assistants should treat those duties as a strong operational signal: use only employer-approved tools and workflows, preserve confidentiality, and ensure authorized professional review.

Lower-risk learning uses

Using public or entirely fictitious information, AI may help you:

- practice interviews;
- learn general legal vocabulary;
- create study questions;
- generate fictitious document-review exercises;
- practice chronology creation;
- compare public explanations of legal concepts;
- rehearse professional communication;
- learn spreadsheet, PDF, or document-management concepts.

Never expose protected information to unapproved AI

Do not paste, upload, summarize, or expose real:

- client or prospective-client information;
- privileged communications;
- attorney work product;
- legal strategy;
- nonpublic evidence, discovery, contracts, or investigation material;
- personal, medical, financial, immigration, or employment data;
- passwords, tokens, authentication factors, or filing credentials;
- confidential internal policies or business information.

Verify AI output

AI can fabricate or misstate cases, citations, statutes, quotations, dates, procedural requirements, facts, and legal conclusions. For any legal research or drafting support:

1. identify the jurisdiction and date;
 2. retrieve the primary or authoritative source;
 3. verify the citation and quoted language;
 4. confirm that the authority is current and applicable;
 5. follow employer review and supervision requirements;
 6. never substitute AI output for authorized legal judgment.
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17. Job search and interview preparation

Resume evidence to emphasize

Use truthful evidence of:

- research and source verification;
- professional writing and proofreading;
- document preparation;
- case or project coordination;
- deadline-sensitive work;
- confidential records handling;
- interviewing or information gathering;
- document review and organization;
- Microsoft 365, PDF, case-management, or document-management tools you actually know;
- practice-area knowledge you actually possess;
- bilingual communication where relevant;
- privacy, security, and responsible-AI awareness.

Do not claim legal authority, court experience, research-platform proficiency, certification, ABA approval, licensing, practice-area expertise, or years of experience you do not actually have.

Interview scenarios to practice

Prepare examples for questions such as:

- How do you verify legal or factual research before relying on it?
- What would you do if a client asked you for legal advice?
- How do you protect privileged and confidential information?
- How do you track several deadlines across multiple matters?
- Tell me about an error you caught before it caused a larger problem.

- What would you do if an attorney requested a filing but a key fact or attachment appeared inconsistent?
- How would you handle an AI-generated citation you could not verify?
- How would you respond to an urgent email asking you to send sensitive documents through an unapproved channel?

Strong answers combine accuracy, source verification, confidentiality, service, escalation, and respect for legal-role boundaries.

Questions for the employer

Ask about:

- supervision structure;
- practice areas;
- onboarding and training;
- case-management, research, filing, and document systems;
- expected schedule and overtime;
- hybrid or remote policies;
- confidentiality and cybersecurity training;
- AI-use policy;
- performance expectations;
- certification or continuing-education support;
- tuition reimbursement;
- promotion paths;
- repayment obligations for employer-paid education.

Get important repayment terms in writing.

18. Twelve-week entry plan and progression

Weeks 1-2 — Understand the occupation and jurisdiction

- Read O*NET 23-2011.00 and the current BLS profile.
- Review 15–20 local job postings.
- Identify repeated education, software, practice-area, and experience requirements.
- Separate ordinary paralegal employment from legal administrative work and from limited-license programs.
- Identify the jurisdiction's rules that affect nonlawyer work.

Weeks 3-4 — Strengthen research and document skills

- Practice public-source research and source logging.
- Improve word processing, spreadsheets, PDF tools, and document comparison.
- Practice fictitious case-file organization.
- Review confidentiality, phishing, MFA, redaction, and secure-sharing fundamentals.

Weeks 5-6 — Learn substantive support fundamentals

- Study general litigation, transaction, or practice-area vocabulary.
- Practice chronologies, document summaries, issue lists, and research logs using public or fictitious facts.
- Practice distinguishing factual information from legal advice.
- Learn the escalation path for uncertain authority.

Weeks 7-8 — Build application evidence

- Create a truthful targeted resume.
- Prepare examples demonstrating research, accuracy, confidentiality, organization, and escalation.
- Practice interviews.
- Build an application tracker.

Weeks 9-10 — Verify education and funding before paying

Check:

- total tuition and fees;
- employer demand for the credential;
- institutional recognition or accreditation;
- ABA program approval if claimed;
- state regulation or licensing relevance;
- FAFSA eligibility where relevant;
- American Job Center or workforce support;
- scholarships;
- employer educational assistance;
- Section 127 terms;
- refund, withdrawal, and repayment obligations;
- accommodations and accessibility.

Weeks 11-12 — Apply and refine

- Apply to jobs matching your verified skills.
- Track which requirements repeatedly block progress.
- Improve one verified gap at a time.
- Avoid accumulating credentials that target employers do not value.

Possible progression

With experience and, where required, additional education, certification, regulation, registration, or licensure, pathways may include:

- senior paralegal;
- litigation paralegal;
- corporate or contracts paralegal;

- immigration paralegal;
- real estate paralegal;
- e-discovery or litigation-support specialist;
- legal operations specialist;
- case-management or practice-support lead;
- compliance or investigations support;
- contract administration;
- paralegal manager;
- limited legal-service professional only where a jurisdiction provides a separate authorization and all requirements are met;
- further formal legal education.

Progression is not automatic, and some pathways involve materially different authorization or education.

19. Verification checklist, sources, disclaimers, authorship, and license

Verify before making a decision

- ☐ exact duties in the current job posting;
- ☐ jurisdiction-specific unauthorized-practice rules;
- ☐ required supervision and authority;
- ☐ education and experience requirements;
- ☐ whether a claimed certificate is education or individual certification;
- ☐ whether a claimed ABA status applies to the education program rather than the individual;
- ☐ institutional accreditation or recognition;
- ☐ state or provincial regulation, registration, or licensing requirements;
- ☐ work authorization;
- ☐ salary, hours, overtime, and benefits;
- ☐ confidentiality, privilege, cybersecurity, and records policies;
- ☐ employer AI-use policy;
- ☐ training costs, refund rules, and repayment obligations;
- ☐ FAFSA, workforce, scholarship, or employer-support eligibility;
- ☐ SNIES status for Colombian higher-education programs where relevant;
- ☐ actual registration status of any program marketed as Registered Apprenticeship;
- ☐ accommodation process if needed.

Controlled sources reviewed for this edition

United States occupation and labor market

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Professional scope, education, regulation, and AI

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- Ministerio de Educación Nacional — SNIES information:
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Education, workforce, and employer support

- Federal Student Aid — FAFSA student steps: <https://studentaid.gov/articles/fafsa-student-steps/>
- U.S. Department of Labor — American Job Centers:
<https://www.dol.gov/agencies/eta/american-job-centers>

- Internal Revenue Service — educational-assistance FAQ update, April 2026: <https://www.irs.gov/newsroom/updates-to-frequently-asked-questions-about-educational-assistance-programs>

Current private U.S. market estimates

- Indeed — Paralegal: <https://www.indeed.com/career/paralegal/salaries>
- ZipRecruiter — Paralegal: <https://www.ziprecruiter.com/Salaries/Paralegal-Salary>

Important disclaimers

This guide does not guarantee employment, wages, admission, funding, apprenticeship registration, certification, promotion, licensing, accommodation, or employer reimbursement. Private salary estimates use different methods and are not government statistics.

This guide does not authorize the practice of law. The definition of legal practice and permitted work of nonlawyers vary by jurisdiction. Follow applicable law, court and agency rules, regulator and bar rules, professional-responsibility requirements, employer policy, supervision, and assigned authority.

A paralegal education certificate is not the same as individual certification. ABA approval applies to qualifying education programs, not to individuals. State or provincial regulation and limited legal-service licensing are separate concepts.

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